The whole squad attends each game, so that if anyone doesn't feel like playing in the afternoon, there's always someone to fill in for him. In one game, Kiwi cricketer Hamish Marshall and Aussie Greg Blewett got absolutely wasted at the lunch and couldn't go in to bat in the afternoon.

Lashings has also afforded me the privilege of playing with some great legends of the game, and my own cricketing heroes – Richie Richardson, who is the club captain, Sir Viv Richards, and that great gentleman of the gentlemen's game, Alvin Kallicharran. It has been wonderful for me to talk to these guys about cricket and hear about all their great experiences. Sir Viv, for one, has some great stories to tell. I remember one particular tale about Aussie fast bowler Craig McDermott.

Apparently McDermott used to chirp quite a lot when he bowled. During one Test in Australia, he was getting so mouthy that the West Indians decided to teach him a lesson. They waited for McDermott to come in to bat at the tail-end of the Aussie innings, and then proceeded to absolutely pepper him with short stuff. Apparently he was getting pinned left, right and centre. I mean, can you imagine what it must be like out there when you're on the receiving end of balls bowled by the likes of Malcolm Marshall, Joel Garner and Michael Holding when they've got it in for you? I'd crap myself. And I'm an opening batsman, not a tail-ender.

Malcolm Marshall, in particular, was as scary as hell. I remember Desmond Haynes – another great West Indian batsman of that golden era – telling me of an incident that occurred in England's 1984 tour to the West Indies, when Marshall bowled to English captain Mike Gatting. The ball went straight through Gatting's grill and smacked him so hard, they found pieces of bone from Gatting's broken nose embedded in the ball.

But to get back to poor Craig McDermott: according to Sir Viv, they were so determined to rough him up that, when McDermott offered a simple catch to one of the West Indians fielding at gully – no doubt just wanting to get the hell out of there – the guy deliberately dropped the ball so that they could continue physically abusing him. That's Test cricket for you. It's a big man's game and there's no place to hide. I believe that for the remainder of his Test career, whenever Craig McDermott played against the West Indies, he was unusually subdued.

Apart from the social side of things, Lashings also gives you some decent time in the middle during the winter months, depending on how seriously you want to take the game. You'll often come up against a team that has a